



THE WEIRDNESS OF WAR AND PESTILENCE

Lovecraftian Perspectives on the Cataclysms of the Early 20th Century

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FOUNDATIONS OF HORROR

The five years of 1914 through 1919 transformed the planet through industrialized slaughter and a global pandemic. These events fertilized the imaginative conditions for American weird fiction and Lovecraft's oeuvre.

CONSCIOUS INFLUENCE: THE GREAT WAR

A PERSONAL WOUND

Unlike the pandemic, Lovecraft processed the war with clear intent through several fictional treatments. He attempted twice to enlist, driven by a death wish and a yearning for purpose.

THE VOCABULARY OF HORROR

The war provided a thematic lexicon: the grinding efficiency of artillery, the creeping death of gas, and the tragic fragility of the human mind.

THE MACHINE OF DEATH

- ◇ **Gas Warfare:** Transformed soldiers into technological monsters in alien masks.
- ◇ **Artillery:** Indiscriminate rain of fire delivered from miles away, measuring progress in inches and deaths in millions.
- ◇ **The Haber-Bosch Process:** Fertilizer tech turned into an engine for endless munitions.
- ◇ **Technological Nihilism:** Progress realized as a force of misery rather than enhancement.



THE FRAGILITY OF SANITY



SHELLSHOCK

Psychological affliction that bewildered the primitive medical establishment of the time.



LOSS OF IDENTITY

Combat trauma undoing the character, as soldiers returned as shells of their former selves.



COSMIC CHAOS

The world itself seemed designed to drive people insane, a recurring Lovecraftian motif.

THE DEEP AND THE DOOMED



DAGON

A tragic interpretation of PTSD. The ancient gods stand in for the actual horrors of war, leading to addiction and suicide.



THE TEMPLE

Prussian rationalism vs. supernatural curse. A commander's national chauvinism becomes his mechanism of destruction.

CHARNEL HOUSES & ANCESTRAL GRIEF



HERBERT WEST (PART V)

Set in Flanders. West uses the "abundant supply of freshly killed men" for his ghastly experiments. A mirror to Lovecraft's own suicidal ideation during the war.



THE RATS IN THE WALLS

A bereaved father's descent. The war "ate his boy," and he in turn succumbs to a literal, hereditary cannibalism driven by grief.

UNCONSCIOUS INFLUENCE: THE 1918 PANDEMIC

A PROFOUND DISTRUST

Both of Lovecraft's parents died in institutions; medicine was barely professionalized and failed him personally, repeatedly, and terminally.

AN IRONIC EPIDEMIOLOGY

The 1918 flu took the young and healthy through cytokine storms in an ironic inversion of natural mortality which was echoed throughout his fiction.

THE UNREPORTED PANDEMIC

Killing American civilians at over ten times the rate of WWI's combat casualties,
yet silenced in cultural memory. Lovecraft processed this "invisible horror"
unconsciously through layers of dread.

THE PLAGUE-DAEMON

In "**Herbert West—Reanimator**," the typhoid outbreak is a clear stand-in for the 1918 flu. The medical establishment is cast as stagnant Puritans vs. radical, amoral mechanists.

"**The Last Test**" explores the spread of fear through irresponsible media, and medicine is in league with literal devils.



THE INVISIBLE THREAT



METAPHORS FOR THE VIRUS

- **The Dunwich Horror:** An invisible monster rampaging through communities like the flu.
- **The Horror at Martin's Beach:** Gatsbyesque revelers ignorant of the invisible threat just off the coast as a metaphor for the return of influenza through troop movements.
- **The Colour Out of Space:** An indescribable, formless threat that spreads virulent disease and poisons the land, combining the effects of flu and mustard gas.

A FOUNDATION FOR COSMIC NIHILISM

The introduction of mechanized warfare on a continental scale, coupled with a mysterious, planet-wide pandemic, form a compelling basis for Lovecraft's particular cosmic nihilism.

QUESTIONS?

"THE UNIVERSE IS COLD, THOUGH NOT ACTIVELY CRUEL."

Science is real, yet menacing. Technology amplifies, rather than mitigates, human vulnerability.

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IMAGE SOURCES



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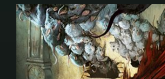
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